What San Diego's 7th-cycle housing need determination is likely to look like

DRAFT — UNVALIDATED

An independent, reproducible forecast of the Regional Housing Need Determination (RHND) that HCD will issue to SANDAG in 2028, built by running HCD's own published 7th-cycle methodology on public data — before the official number arrives.

⚠ **Draft estimate — read this first.** This is an independent, unofficial forecast of a determination HCD will not issue until 2028. It has not been validated by HCD, DOF, or SANDAG. It is intended to inform *preliminary, order-of-magnitude* regional planning conversations — it is **not a substitute** for HCD's determination or SANDAG's allocation process, and it should **not be relied upon for specific planning studies**, housing element work, site inventories, or any decision requiring an adopted number. Figures are approximations that will change with new ACS, LODES, PIT, and DOF releases and with HCD's own methodological choices.

Central draft estimate	Scenario band	6th-cycle determination (2018)
228,584	**179,100 – 228,584**	**171,685**
units, 2028–2039 projection period	driven by HCD's own formula & vintage choices	adopted allocation total, 2021–2029

What we did

HCD has already issued 7th-cycle determinations to the five-year-cycle counties, and those letters disclose the full methodology — every adjustment line, formula, dataset, and national benchmark. We rebuilt that method from its public inputs (ACS, LODES, HUD point-in-time counts, DOF projections and estimates, HCD annual-progress reports, CAL FIRE damage inspections, Caltrans forecasts) and **proved the rebuild against the two published determinations** before applying it to San Diego County:

- **Mono County** (final letter, Jan 2026): 10 of 11 adjustment lines reproduced within 0–4 units; the one remaining line (the PUMS overcrowding×cost-burden overlap) is a geography limitation of public microdata that does not apply to San Diego.
- **Humboldt County** (final letter, Jul 2025): 8 of 11 adjustment lines reproduced exactly — including overcrowding, cost burden, and the overlap — and the vacancy line within 1 unit.

The full line-by-line comparison, including everything that could *not* be reproduced and why, is in validation_mono.md.

The logic, in one paragraph

HCD's 7th-cycle method starts from DOF's projected households at the end of the projection period, then adds what existing conditions already generate: units needed to reach healthy vacancy rates (2% owner / 7% renter), to bring

overcrowding and housing cost burden down to the national rates (less an overlap credit so no household is counted twice), to replace demolitions, to house people counted in the point-in-time homeless count, and to cover disaster losses — then subtracts projected occupied units at the start of the period. For San Diego the result is dominated by the **cost-burden line** (136,160 units in the central scenario): 43.4% of the county's households pay 30%+ of income for housing against 31.7% nationally. Growth, the line that dominated the 6th cycle, contributes only about 54,405.

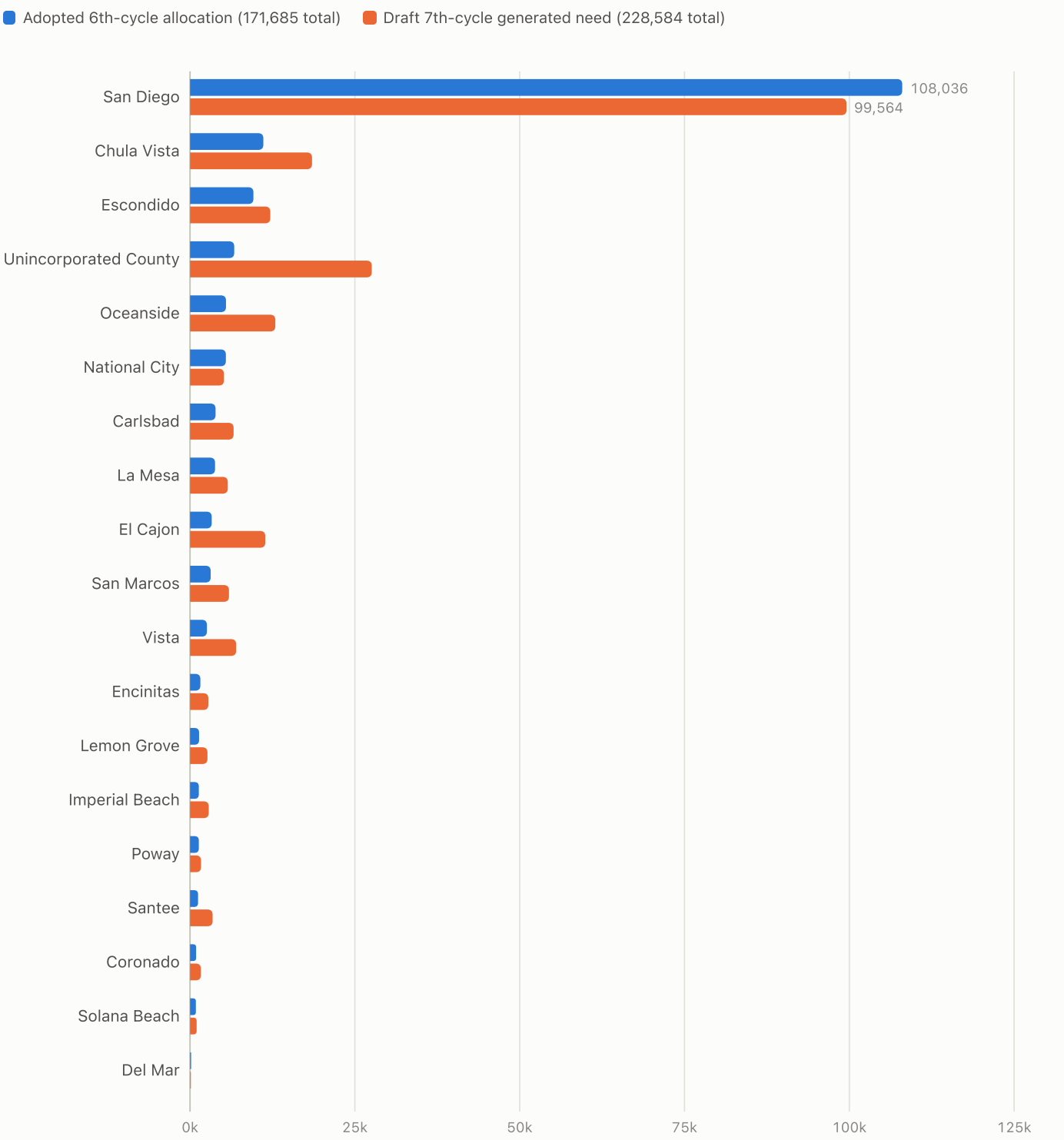
Why this is informative for preliminary SANDAG planning

- **The magnitude arrives before the letter does.** Every scenario lands well above the 6th cycle's 171,685 — electeds and staff can see the order of magnitude, and which lines drive it, three years before HCD hands the region the number.
- **The band is HCD's own uncertainty, not ours.** The spread (179,100–228,584) comes from choices HCD itself made differently in its two published letters (two formulas for the overcrowding/cost-burden lines), plus data vintages and the projection-period end date. Nothing in the band is an invented assumption.
- **The allocation conversation can start early.** The jurisdiction table below shows where need is *generated* under HCD's definitions versus where the current allocation method would *send* it — the structural tension the 7th-cycle methodology fight will be about.

None of this substitutes for the official process: HCD consults DOF on custom projections we cannot see, and both the method and the data vintages can change by 2028.

Per-jurisdiction: 6th cycle vs draft 7th cycle

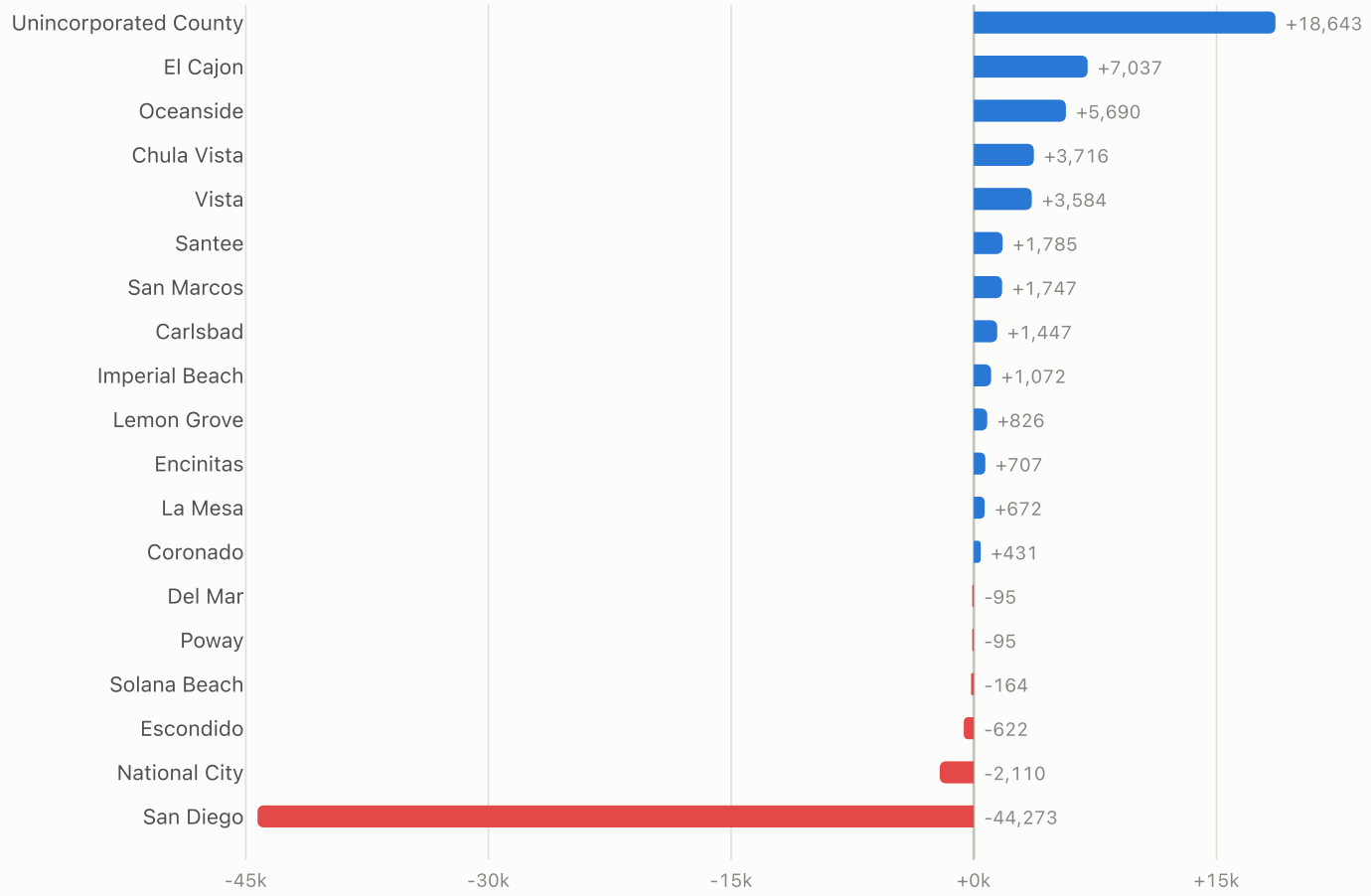
Each jurisdiction's **adopted 6th-cycle allocation** (its current RHNA obligation) next to the **existing need its own residents generate** under HCD's 7th-cycle definitions (central scenario, computed from place-level ACS data; regional growth and homelessness shares are distributed by household share and labeled as such in the data file).



Sorted by 6th-cycle allocation. Source: SANDAG Final 6th Cycle RHNA Plan Table 1.1; jurisdiction_existing_need.csv (this project).

The gap: who generates need vs who the method would allocate it to

If SANDAG's adopted 6th-cycle allocation method (65% transit stations, 35% jobs) were simply rerun at the draft 7th-cycle total, the gap between what a jurisdiction's residents generate and what the method assigns looks like this:



Gap = generated – allocated, in units, at the 228,584-unit central scenario. Positive: residents generate more need than the method would allocate there. Reading and caveats in jurisdiction_gap.md.

Reading the San Diego shift

The City of San Diego stands out twice in these charts, and both shifts are properties of the *measurement*, not of anything that changed in the city.

Why its draft generated need (99,564) sits below its 6th-cycle allocation (108,036) even though the regional total rose by a third: the city's housing-stress rates are almost exactly the regional rates — overcrowding 6.2% in the city vs 6.7% countywide, cost burden 42.9% vs 43.4% (both far above the national 31.7% benchmark) — so under HCD's definitions the city generates need in proportion to the households it houses: 45% of the region's households, 44% of the generated need. Its 6th-cycle allocation was never proportional to households: it was driven by infrastructure.

Why the allocation method sends it 143,837 (a 44,273-unit gap): the 6th-cycle method allocates 65% of all units by transit stations, and the city holds 100 of the region's 154 rail and Rapid stations and 101 of its 140 major transit stops — 67% of the transit pot — plus 56% of the jobs component, for 63% of the total. The −44k gap is the wedge between owning two-thirds of the transit infrastructure and housing 45% of the households. The same wedge, with the opposite sign, is what the high-overcrowding, high-cost-burden jurisdictions absorb: Unincorporated County (+18,643), El Cajon (+7,037), Oceanside (+5,690), Chula Vista (+3,716), Vista (+3,584).

Because the shift comes from the allocation formula's geometry rather than from conditions inside the city, no census-tract pattern within the City of San Diego "accounts for" it. A tract-level map of the city would answer a different (and worthwhile) question — *where inside the city the overcrowding and cost-burden need concentrates* — and can be built from the same ACS tables at tract geography if wanted; it would not move any number in these charts.

Data table: all jurisdictions

Jurisdiction	6th-cycle adopted	7th generated (draft)	7th alloc. @ 6th method	Gap
San Diego	108,036	99,564	143,837	-44,273
Unincorporated County	6,700	27,563	8,920	+18,643
Chula Vista	11,105	18,501	14,786	+3,716
Oceanside	5,443	12,937	7,247	+5,690
Escondido	9,607	12,169	12,791	-622
El Cajon	3,280	11,404	4,368	+7,037
Vista	2,561	6,993	3,410	+3,584
Carlsbad	3,873	6,603	5,157	+1,447
San Marcos	3,116	5,896	4,149	+1,747
La Mesa	3,797	5,728	5,056	+672

National City	5,437	5,129	7,239	-2,110
Santee	1,219	3,409	1,624	+1,785
Imperial Beach	1,329	2,841	1,769	+1,072
Encinitas	1,554	2,777	2,070	+707
Lemon Grove	1,359	2,635	1,809	+826
Poway	1,319	1,661	1,756	-95
Coronado	912	1,645	1,214	+431
Solana Beach	875	1,002	1,166	-164
Del Mar	163	122	217	-95

The determination, line by line (central scenario)

HCD Attachment-2 layout vs the 2018 determination

#	Line	Draft 7th cycle	6th cycle (2018)
1	Population: 2039-06-15	3,423,080	3,613,215
2	- Group Quarters Population	-118,738	-118,075
3	Household (HH) Population	3,304,342	3,495,140
4	Projected Households	1,290,675	1,251,115
5a	+ Vacancy Adjustment, Existing Households	26,725	31,500
5b	+ Vacancy Adjustment, Projected Households	2,326	–
6	+ Overcrowding Adjustment	38,201	38,700
7	+ Cost-burden Adjustment	136,160	–
8	- Overcrowded and Cost-burdened Overlap	-34,463	–
9	+ Replacement Adjustment Demolitions (0.10%)	1,236	6,255
11	+ Jobs Housing Relationship Adjustment	0	–
12	+ Homelessness Adjustment	3,965	–
13	+ State of Emergency Adjustment	28	–
14	- Occupied Units (HHs) projected 2028-12-31	-1,236,270	-1,155,883
15	Preliminary Regional Housing Need (excl. seasonal)	228,584	–

10	+ Replacement Adjustment Seasonal/Recreational/Occasional	0	–
16	+ Feasible Jobs/Housing Balance Adjustment	0	–
total	**7th Cycle Regional Housing Need Determination**	**228,584**	**171,685**

All eight scenarios, with every line and the underlying rates: rhnd_7th_cycle_sandag.md / .csv

Scenario totals

All eight scenarios

Scenario (vintage · lines-6/7 formula · due date)	Total
mono vintage · difference · jun2031	228,584
mono vintage · difference · jan2031	226,825
newest vintage · difference · jun2031	223,869
newest vintage · difference · jan2031	222,109
mono vintage · dilution · jun2031	185,431
mono vintage · dilution · jan2031	183,672
newest vintage · dilution · jun2031	180,860
newest vintage · dilution · jan2031	179,100

"difference" = the Mono letter's rate-difference formula; "dilution" = the Humboldt letter's units-to-reach-the-US-rate formula. Vintages: mono = 2019–23 ACS / LODES 2022 / PIT 2024; newest = 2020–24 ACS / LODES 2023 / PIT 2025.

Detail documents and data

- README.md — what was run, vintages, band drivers, rerun triggers
- validation_mono.md — the Mono and Humboldt reproductions, line by line, with every known limitation
- rhnd_7th_cycle_sandag.md / .csv — the full determination table, all scenarios
- jurisdiction_existing_need.csv — per-jurisdiction lines (computed vs distributed columns flagged in the header)
- jurisdiction_gap.md — the gap analysis
- data/manifest.yaml — provenance of every source file (URL, vintage, license, fetch date)
- rhnd/ — the pipeline itself; rerunnable when new ACS/LODES/DOF vintages land

Use limits: draft, unvalidated, approximate. Produced for preliminary regional planning discussion only. Not an HCD or SANDAG document; not validated by HCD, DOF, or SANDAG; not suitable for housing elements, site inventories, environmental review, or any specific planning study. The official 7th-cycle determination will be issued by HCD in 2028 following statutory consultation with SANDAG and DOF.

Regenerated 2026-10-17 by `rhnd/make_report.py`; every figure traces to a source in `data/manifest.yaml` through the `rhnd/` pipeline. Validation tolerances enforced by `tests/test_rhnd.py`.